would often contrast the situation in that state with what he claimed was ‘development’ in the BJP-ruled states. And then would come the final promise. ‘Give me sixty months, I will bring change!’ Interestingly, Team Modi had ensured that trained cadres would mix with the crowds, both to gauge the response and to try and enthuse the crowd at the right moments.

I attended one Modi rally during the campaign. It was in Meerut in February 2014, a rally that was taking place against the backdrop of the riots in the neighbouring district of Muzaffarnagar. The crowds were massive. People from the entire western UP belt had come by the truckloads to listen to Modi; some had even climbed up electric poles. For at least sixty seconds before he spoke, the crowds kept chanting his name and blowing conch shells (the rally had been branded Vijay Shanknad Rally). When Modi contrasted a ‘powerless’ UP with a fully electrified Gujarat, there were wild cheers.

Sonia Gandhi had just attacked Modi for sowing what she described as ‘*zehar ki kheti*’ (fields of poison). Modi now hit back, accusing the Congress of spreading the poison of communal division. Rahul had always been dismissively referred to as ‘shehzada’ by Modi. Sonia was usually given a little more respect, though in the 2002 campaign he had dubbed her the ‘lady from Italy’. Now, the gloves were off again as Modi called for a ‘*Congress Mukt Bharat*’. ‘The poison of vote bank politics has been spread by the Congress and a family which has ruled the country for most of the years since independence,’ he said, rousing the crowd into a frenzy.

The direct attack on the Gandhis was deliberate. Good governance was the overarching theme of Modi’s campaign, with the idea of drawing in new voters to the BJP; but Modi was also keen to make ‘dynasty’ an issue—it was ‘us’ versus ‘them’, son-of-the-soil karyakarta versus the born-to-rule First Family. Non-Congress leaders have often been accused of being a little intimidated by the Nehru–Gandhis; now, Modi was actually calling for dismantling the edifice of the Congress party.

When Modi first called Rahul a shehzada, I had asked him about it, suggesting that the tone and words sounded politically incorrect. Modi was characteristically defiant. *‘Kya galat kaha hai? Woh to shehzada hi toh hai’*